

WHITBY ENGLAND



The Great British Seaside Dish

It's hard to think of a more atmospheric UK coastal resort than Whitby in North Yorkshire, its red-roofed houses hugging the Esk River below the striking ruins of an ancient abbey. Generations of vacationers have wiggled their toes in Whitby's golden sands and strolled along the bustling harbor, building up an appetite for that greatest of seaside pleasures: deep-fried fish and chips.



The sea is embedded in Whitby's history – from humble medieval herring port to booming 18th-century whaling town – while its shipyards built the vessels that took England's greatest explorer, Captain James Cook, on his remarkable voyages of discovery. Even today, there's a real air of romance and excitement on any visit, from the steam trains that chug into the harborside station to the higgledy-piggledy cottages of the Georgian old town.

While Whitby and its glorious sandy beach remains at heart a traditional pail-and-shovel resort, there are boutique stirrings among the town's hotels and B&Bs, and a new wave of café-bars and restaurants doing great things with shellfish, sea bass, oysters, and lobster, along with other locally sourced produce. But there's still only one must-have dish on a day trip to Whitby – good old-fashioned fish and chips.

For such a well-known dish, its origins are obscure. The fried-fish dishes of immigrant Portuguese and Spanish Jews were already popular in London during Victorian times, while contemporary northern mill workers were enthusiastic consumers of fried “chips” made from potatoes dug from the rich Lancashire soil. When the two came together, a cheap, nutritious working-class delicacy was born. It quickly took hold across the nation – nowhere in England is more than 70 miles (110 km) from the coast – but for the quintessential fish-and-chips experience, there's still no beating the beguiling marriage of sand, sun, and sea air.

In Whitby, chunky cod and haddock fillets are the mainstays of carry-outs and upmarket restaurants alike, deep-fried in golden batter, sprinkled with salt and malt vinegar, and served with a mountain of chips. Batter recipes are zealously guarded, and the best places are proud to say they fry their fish and potatoes in traditional beef dripping or lard. For purists, the only accompaniment is mushy peas (marrowfat peas, cooked down to a purée), and if the whole lot is eaten out of paper on the beach, so much the better. The harborside cafés and restaurants of Whitby are selling more than just a dish – those heady salt-and-vinegar tones evoke nothing less than a collective national memory of seaside jaunts and happy holidays.

What Else to Eat

Fortune's (www.fortuneskippers.co.uk) is Whitby's only traditional smokehouse, tucked up a cobbled lane in the old town, just beyond the bottom of the 199 Steps. It's been a Fortune family concern since 1872, producing what many argue are England's best oak- and beech-smoked kippers – locals, visitors, and TV chefs alike all make the pilgrimage to the unassuming smokehouse and shop that lies sheltered under the east-side cliffs. Kippers are smoked Atlantic herring, still prepared by hand at Fortune's, alongside a delicious kipper pâté and smoked salmon, haddock, and bacon. A pair of Fortune's kippers is a true taste of Whitby, and many local hotels and restaurants serve Fortune's kippers to their guests.

Left Whitby viewed from the end of West Pier

The Best Places to Eat Fish and Chips

Magpie Café moderate

The venerable Magpie Café – run by three generations of the same family over several decades – is synonymous with fish and chips, both in Whitby and far beyond. It's a traditional-looking black-and-white building on the harborside, right by the fish market, unremarkable from the outside save for the line snaking down the steps and along the street, in any weather, at any time of the year (reservations aren't usually accepted).

The lure is simply spectacular fish and chips – and not just cod and haddock, but plaice, skate, monkfish, lemon sole, or halibut, sourced wherever possible directly from Whitby fishing boats or fish merchants and perfectly fried in their own-recipe batter. The same fish also comes grilled or poached, while a very long menu also offers time-honored Magpie favorites from Whitby crab and kippers to seafood chowder and lobster thermidor. Portions are “Yorkshire-sized” (i.e., big), and the long-serving staff are helpful and motherly.

14 Pier Road, Whitby; open 11:30 AM–9 PM daily; www.magpiecafe.co.uk

Also in Whitby

The lines aren't so long, but the fish and chips are still excellent at **Trenchers** (www.trenchersrestaurant.co.uk; *moderate*), where you can also watch the fryers at work. For posh fish and chips, and a more upmarket fish and seafood experience all around, **Green's** (www.greensofwhitby.com; *expensive*) sets the local standard – the boat skippers who land their fish are name-checked on the menu.

Also in England

Every town and city in England has a favorite local “chippy” (fish-and-chips restaurant or carry-out), and annual competitions and awards anoint the best, often in otherwise unsung places. **Colmans** in South Shields, also in the northeast (www.colmansfishandchips.com; *inexpensive*) is a classic of its kind, in business since 1926, and while **Harry Ramsdens** (www.harryramsdens.co.uk) is now a well-known national chain, the original restaurant in Guiseley, outside Leeds, still draws pilgrims.

Around the World

The dish has followed the English around the world, from New York to New Zealand. In Hong Kong, there's classic cod and chips at **Dot Cod** (www.dotcod.com; *expensive*), an upmarket seafood restaurant and oyster bar, while Sydney, Australia, is renowned for quality beachside fish and chips, like those from **Mongers** (www.mongers.com.au; *inexpensive*), found at Manly and Bondi beaches.

